Contradiction Memo

Assumption Being Challenged

An assumption worth challenging in our business case is that students will check DineCheck regularly before choosing where to eat. Our proposed system depends on students finding enough value in current dining information to add another step to their routine.

The interviews suggest that this value depends on the situation. Some students face meaningful consequences when information is wrong, while others can adapt without much inconvenience.

Contradicting Evidence

Interview 3 provides the clearest contradiction. The student usually visits a familiar cafe because it is already along their route. They do not check online before regular visits and choose from whatever is available. When pastries were unavailable, they bought coffee and ate food from their bag. They considered this a minor inconvenience.

The student said they might use a new tool when looking for a specific item or checking unusual hours, but probably would not check it before every visit. This suggests that unavailable food does not always create a strong enough problem to change an established habit.

Interview 1 also complicates the assumption. That student sometimes visits without confirming service because checking takes time. Even a student who has experienced an unsuccessful trip may skip an information tool if using it feels slower than proceeding with a familiar option.

Why This Matters

These findings do not show that DineCheck lacks value. They show that experiencing a dining inconvenience does not automatically lead to regular use.

Interview 1 described losing about 12 minutes after visiting an open cafe whose kitchen had stopped serving. Interview 2 described a sold-out vegetarian bowl that led to more walking and about $4 in additional spending. Those situations provide stronger reasons to check availability than a routine visit where several acceptable alternatives exist.

If we assume frequent use across the student population, we may overestimate adoption and the benefits used to justify development and maintenance costs. We should distinguish students who need reliable information for a particular decision from students whose current routines already work well.

My Advice

I recommend that we focus the initial evaluation on three situations: short breaks between classes, choosing a specific or suitable meal, and checking unusual operating hours. These situations give students a concrete reason to seek information before leaving.

We should compare DineCheck with participants' current methods and measure whether it improves the decision. Useful measures include time needed to find an acceptable option, correct interpretation of serving status, and whether participants return to the tool without prompting.

Until testing supports a stronger claim, our business case should describe DineCheck as a tool for reducing uncertainty in particular dining situations. We should treat regular use as a hypothesis to test rather than an expected outcome.